

APPLE ARCADE PITCH · CHIE COLLECTIVE

STONE BIRD

THE CONTRACT ERA

A story-driven vertical air-combat epic across Africa, for iPhone, iPad and Apple TV.

Playable beta on TestFlight now · Tachena Nhubu, Chie Collective



THE HOOK

Fly your mother's jet.

Farai Moyo's mother Tendai was the pilot the plateau called Stone Bird. On Farai's certification flight, a raid brings Tendai down. Farai flies west in Goredema, the prototype everyone is hunting, and takes contracts on Africa's Atlantic coast under a name she can't use.

The jobs lead to Meridian, the house arming both sides of every war, and to an ace who knows exactly how her mother flew.



THE STORY

Three acts, twelve contracts, two endings

PROLOGUE · ACT I

The Raid and the Coast

A flight over Great Zimbabwe ends in a raid. Farai lands on the Atlantic coast flying contracts for the Broker, until the Iron Coast's ace, Harmattan, hears how she flies.

ACT II

The Contract War

Gun-runners off Cabo Verde, a night convoy through the Delta carrying Tendai's flight book, a storm duel off São Tomé, and Meridian's depot at Djenné.

ACT III

The Hill

Stone or gold: her answer to Meridian sets the road. Both run through the Skeleton Coast, Victoria Falls and Kariba to the Kraal, a fortress in the air over the Hill.

A jeli, a West African storyteller, opens every contract: “Listen. Before the contracts, before the gold, there was a girl from the plateau, and a mother the plateau called Stone Bird.”

Real places, from the plateau to the Atlantic

Contract	Where	What happens
Prologue	Hungwe range, Great Zimbabwe	A certification flight becomes a raid
1	An Atlantic estuary	Escort a cargo convoy past Iron Coast gunboats
2	Bandiagara Escarpment	Stop the armour; the cliff villages are not targets
3	The Erg, by Araouane	Gun lines in the dunes, and a voice that knows her name
4	The Iron Coast shipyard	Strike the yard with the house's best pilots overhead
5	Cabo Verde	Catch the gun-running freighters low over the sea
6	The Niger Delta	A night convoy under the patrol boats' searchlights
7	São Tomé	Harmattan, in the worst storm of the year
8	Djenné	Meridian's depot upstream of the Great Mosque
9	The Skeleton Coast	The Echoes: copies of Goredema that mirror you
10	Victoria Falls	Stop the armoured train before the bridge
11	Kariba	Bombers come from behind for the dam
12	The Hill, Great Zimbabwe	The Kraal, Meridian's fortress in the air

HOW IT PLAYS

Short contracts, a long campaign

Briefing

The jeli sets the scene; the Broker names the job and the pay.



Fly

One finger flies, the guns fire themselves. Four to six minutes a contract.



Get paid

Payout in gold mithqal, plus bonuses for what she protects.



The hangar

Nyeleni sells, upgrades and lets you test-fire every weapon first.

A prologue and twelve contracts make the campaign. Restoring Goredema's own systems unlocks Tendai's flight-recorder tapes; finishing opens the Goredema sky, the hardest of four difficulties, and an archive to fly any contract again.

THE ARMOURY

Eight weapons, three marks each

Guns: twin 20 mm cannons, then a six-barrel rotary, then rotary plus high-explosive cannons.

Support: heat-seeking missiles, a plasma fan, a flak turret, a seeker swarm and an ember mortar. Each can hit only what it physically could: heat-seekers need an engine, flak bursts at altitude.

Heavy: the Sun Lance beam, which overheats; the Mosi ball, which punches through a line; the Hammerhead, for armour. Each Mk III changes how it fights, not just its numbers.

Test range: every weapon and mark fires live in the hangar before you buy it.



BIG MOMENTS

Call the Rainmaker

Goredema throws a charge into the sky, it bursts into a storm, and white-hot rain comes down on everything under it, air and ground, ending in a thunderclap. The Storm Discharge, charged in battle, chains lightning from target to target.

Against them, more than 30 kinds of enemy: Shades that cloak, Echoes that mirror her, Kestrels that sweep their wings to dash, gunboats, an armoured train, a river monitor and the Kraal.



THE RIVAL

Harmattan knows her name

The Iron Coast House's ace was one of Tendai's pupils. He hunts Farai across the coast in duels that play like a real dogfight: he never hovers, he steers like an aircraft, and he comes round from behind.

“You fly like someone I used to know, stone bird. Next time, it's me.”

On the stone road he ends the war on her wing.



THE CHOICE

STONE OR GOLD?

Meridian offers more gold than anyone on the coast has ever seen, for Tendai's book and Farai's silence. Take it, and fight the last act with Meridian's money. Refuse, and the book goes to every house on the coast.

Two roads through Act III. Two endings. The player's answer, not a dialogue tree.

THE CRAFT

Made by a filmmaker

Look

Afrofuturism rooted in real design: Ndebele zigzags, clay-dot markings and the soapstone birds of Great Zimbabwe. Hand-built terrain with real-time lighting, weather, mist and night.

Sound

An original score built on mbira, kora and talking drum (more on the next slide). Every weapon has its own designed sound, Mk III included, and the radio is mixed for a voice cast, recorded next.

Story

Told like a radio drama while you fly, with helmet cut-ins, a jeli's framing and an afterword for every contract. A 305-line script is written and ready to record.

THE SOUNDTRACK

An original score, and an album

Sixteen tracks, about 53 minutes: a theme for every contract, the hangar, the title and the flight home, all composed for the game by Tachena Nhubu.

Mbira dzavadzimu in its two interlocking parts, kora, balafon, talking drum, djembe and an amapiano log drum, fused with synths.

Three versions of every track, the same length so the game can switch between them: Afrofuturist; Afrofuturist with mbira; and Great Zimbabwe 1994, the record a Harare studio might have cut that year in a Zimbabwe that was never colonised.

STONE BIRD OST

- | | |
|----------------------|----------------------------|
| 01 Stone Bird | 09 The Cargo Run |
| 02 The Contract Wire | 10 Night Convoy |
| 03 The Raid | 11 The Depot |
| 04 First Contract | 12 The Bone Coast |
| 05 Nyeleni's Hangar | 13 The Smoke That Thunders |
| 06 The Escarpment | 14 Kariba |
| 07 The Erg | 15 The Hill |
| 08 Shipyard Strike | 16 Home |

THE BUILD

Native to Apple, on every screen it runs on

Where	How
iPhone	Drag anywhere to fly; the guns fire on their own
iPad	The play field stays tall; the sides become a Great Zimbabwe cockpit
Apple TV	Siri Remote and game controllers, menus scaled for the room
Controllers	Full support, with on-screen button legends
Saves	Three logbooks, synced through the player's own iCloud
Engine	Swift, SwiftUI and SpriteKit; no third-party engine, no ads, no tracking

Plays fully offline. One build for iPhone, iPad and Apple TV, with a single bundle and shared saves.

Made to be a premium game, not a store

No ads, no purchases

Economy, upgrades and difficulty are tuned for play, not spending. The beta already ships with purchases switched off.

Every Apple screen

Start on iPhone, carry on with a controller on Apple TV: the same logbook follows the player.

A story Arcade doesn't have

A narrative shooter set across Africa, its places and its storytelling treated with care.

Easy to start, deep to master

One-finger flying and four skies, from the Contract sky to Goredema's stone-and-gold challenge.

THE BIGGER PICTURE

The first story in the Stone & Gold universe

An alternate 1990s in which Africa was never colonized: great houses, contract wars and Hungwe engineering, with Great Zimbabwe at its heart. Its places, factions, characters and music are built to carry many games, across genres.

NOW

Stone Bird: The Contract Era

Air combat. Farai, Goredema and the fall of Meridian.



NEXT

A racing game

The same world on the ground:
[working title and premise].



THEN

Stone Bird 2

Farai's story continues, with what players have come to know of the world.

WHERE IT STANDS

Playable end to end, in beta today

Done

- Full campaign: prologue, 12 contracts, both routes and endings
- Four difficulties, archive replays, unlockable livery
- Eight weapons with three marks; hangar test range
- Original score; iCloud saves; iPhone, iPad, Apple TV
- A TestFlight beta in testers' hands

For Arcade

- Story cinematics: a new opening, and an ending scene
- Game Center: achievements and leaderboards
- A Mac version
- Record the voice cast (305 lines, scripted)
- Accessibility: VoiceOver menus, flashing and motion options
- Localization; performance on older devices

WHO MAKES IT

Chie Collective

Tachena Nhubu

Founder, director, developer and composer. A filmmaker working across cinematography and post-production, and an iOS developer, who also wrote the score. Stone Bird is the first game, and it is directed the way a film is.

[Earlier work, credits or apps to name]

Collaborators

[Voice cast, to be recorded]

[Others]

THE BUDGET

\$175,000 to finish it right

What it pays for	USD
Development, 8 months full-time	72,000
Opening and ending cinematics	22,000
Localization into 7 languages, with review	24,000
Professional voice cast, studio and direction	18,000
Engineering support: Mac, older devices	10,000
Testing and an accessibility review	8,000
Legal and accounting	5,000
Contingency, about 10%	16,000
Total	175,000

Paid by milestone

- 30% at signing
\$52,500 · month 0
- 30% at alpha, month 3
\$52,500 · voice recorded, cinematics cut, Game Center and Mac running
- 25% at launch candidate, month 6
\$43,750 · localized, accessible, tested
- 15% at launch, month 8
\$26,250

THE ASK

Bring Stone Bird to Apple Arcade

An Arcade partnership with funding of \$175,000 to direct an opening and an ending cinematic, record the voice cast, add Game Center and Mac, and finish accessibility, localization and polish, for a launch eight months after signing.

The beta is ready to play now on iPhone, iPad and Apple TV.

Play the beta: testflight.apple.com/join/Q4PAGvzU

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